

THE BIG RACE PM Modi with Bihar CM Nitish Kumar, Dy CM Samrat Choudhary of the BJP and the LJP's Chirag Paswan

WHEN TEJASHWI SPEAKS, HE SAYS THE BJP HAD NOT JUST TAKEN AWAY THEIR MLAS BUT ALSO "HIJACKED" THEIR "*CHACHAJI* (NITISH KUMAR)"

contributions as "inconsequential", but public sentiment seems to be tilting in Tejashwi's favour.

It shows in the RJD leader's poll campaign too, with Tejashwi single-handedly taking on the NDA's touring roster of heavyweights on a daily basis. Sahani, whose VIP is fighting in three seats— Gopalganj, Motihari and Jhanjharpur—is with him. The VIP's support base is among the Nishad, Mallah and Sahni sub-castes listed under the EBCs or the Extremely Backward Classes, which make up nearly five per cent of Bihar's population.

Tejashwi and Sahani, 43, have also become quite a hit pair on social media, with odd posts such as the one showing both of them eating fried fish with a side dish of chillies during a chopper ride receiving thousands of likes. Sahani is even heard commenting that "*Bahuton ko mirch lagega* (Many will feel aggrieved)" and it actually panned out that way, with senior BJP leaders rebuking the RJD leader for having non-vegetarian food during Navratras and indulging in the "politics of appeasement". Tejashwi hit back saying the clip was from an earlier date and he had only put it out to expose his critics' "low IQ".

Despite the RJD's entrenched Muslim-Yadav (M-Y) voter base, who together make up around 32 per cent of per cent of the population, Tejashwi has realised that it might not be enough to defeat the NDA in a bipolar contest. In fact, he has been quite pragmatic, fielding Kushwaha and EBC leaders in key seats like Purnia, Aurangabad and Nawada. This includes a number of controversial leaders, including Anita Devi, wife of convicted Kurmi don Ashok Mahto, against former JD(U) president Lalan Singh in Munger; popular leaders Abhay Kushwaha in Aurangabad and Shrawan Kushwaha in Nawada; and upper caste strongman Munna Shukla in Vaishali. Jitendra Kumar, who runs a private school in Panchanpur, Gaya, and has been an NDA voter all through, now believes the RJD's decision to expand their social base and field Kushwaha candidates in Aurangabad and Nawada has "broken the ice" with his community (who are otherwise seen as NDA supporters).

The RJD strategy is supported by the 2023 Bihar caste survey, which showed that OBCs (27 per cent) and EBCs (36 per cent) together constitute